

In June 2014, Syria's civil war was entering its bloodiest phase. Rebel militias had seized large swaths of the country. The Islamic State had set up a de facto capital in the city of Raqqa and would soon rampage across Syria and Iraq.

In Damascus, Syria's capital, President Bashar Assad was running out of money and clinging to power through increasingly brutal means. His regime had launched sarin gas attacks on the city's suburbs and was subjecting rebel-held areas to indiscriminate shelling and bombing.

That same month, an official for Syria's state-owned oil company, Syrian Petroleum Co. (SPC), sent a terse request via fax to H.A. Cable Export Co. Ltd., an import-export firm registered in Cyprus.

The Syrian government wanted help buying drilling equipment — crucial to keep the regime's oil revenue flowing — from an American oil equipment giant, NOV Inc.

The SPC official said he had received a letter from National Oilwell Varco (NOV's name at the time) that referred all sales inquiries to H.A. Cable Export. The Cypriot firm, the official wrote, had been "authorized by National Oil Well Company to supply National Oil Well S/MD's foreign market of American Origin."



*People inspecting debris after a Syrian air force attack in Damascus in 2014. Image: Ebu Muhammed/Anadolu Agency/Getty Images*